Heritage & Culture

Having been ruled by multiple dynasties with varied religious influences, Odisha's culture is a vibrant one that celebrates diversity. The state's built heritage too reflects this, with both Hindu and Buddhist monuments dotting the state.

THE SUN TEMPLE, KONARK

The Sun Temple was built by King Narasimhadeva I in the 12th century AD, and it is now a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The temple, an offering to the Sun God, takes the form of a chariot with 24 wheels and is drawn by seven horses. The Sun Temple is one of the tallest in India, standing at a height of about 227 feet. The massive building features exquisite carvings and three statues of Surya, each receiving the rays of the sun at different times of day. The Sound and Light Show held every evening at the Sun Temple, which uses the latest laser effects, is a sight to behold.

JAGANNATH TEMPLE, PURI

The temple of Lord Jagannath in Puri, which dates back to the 12th century AD, is one of the Char Dhams (or four holiest places of worship). It attracts the devout from all over the world every day of the year. Two massive concentric walls surround the temple. The massive, 214-foot temple itself stands on a raised platform and is an architectural marvel. Interestingly, all three holy idols of the temple are made of wood rather than stone or metal.

DHAULI

Odisha's Buddhist heritage is no less venerable

and the state is home to more than 200 sites. Set on the banks of Daya River, Dhauli or Dhauligiri has a rock edict of Emperor Ashoka. Believed to be the battlefield of the Kalinga war that led to significant changes in Ashoka's beliefs, Dhauli went on to become a major Buddhist centre. One can see a number of stupas, chaityas and pillars at the site. Commemorating the end of the Kalinga war, the Shanti Stupa or 'Peace Pagoda' here has become a place of devotion for many pilgrims. One of the major highlights is Dhauli Kalinga Mahotsav—a three-day annual festival, featuring music, dance and martial art performances.

UDAYAGIRI AND KHANDAGIRI CAVES

Located 7km from Bhubaneswar, these ancient